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RESURGENT UP Congress chief Ajay Rai (second from left) leads a party protest in Lucknow, Sept. 18

UTTAR PRADESH

CONGRESS'S RISING ARC

By Ashish Misra

On September 18, Congress workers led by state president Ajay Rai took to the streets in Lucknow to protest the poor law and order situation and 'encounter' killings in Uttar Pradesh. This was the third big protest after the party's surprisingly good Lok Sabha performance, where it won six of the 17 seats it contested, proof of a new-found confidence. The mood in the Congress is that it's time they took their role of "a main Opposition party" seriously.

With just two MLAs in the UP assembly, and three and a half decades after it last tasted power, that will take some doing. A good start, it feels, will be to strengthen support among the backward classes. To that end, the Congress is eyeing the Pasi caste, the second largest Dalit community in UP after the Jatavs.

On July 21, the party celebrated the death anniversary of the late Congress leader and freedom fighter, Masuriya Din Pasi, a member of the Constituent Assembly who is credited with launching the movement for the abolition of the Criminal Tribes Act (which was finally repealed in 2021). Says Sushil Pandey, a political analyst and professor in the department of history at the Dr Bhimrao Ambedkar University, Lucknow, "During the LS poll campaign, Rahul Gandhi had strongly raised the issue of social justice and the caste census, which benefited the Congress. The Pasis make up about 16 per cent of the total SC population of the state with a significant presence in the Awadh region, which could work to the party's advantage." The party has also promoted state general secretary Sushil Pasi to national secretary.

The first challenge will be in the coming assembly byelections in UP. Sources say INDIA ally Samajwadi Party (SP) is loath to give the Congress more than two seats, but the latter has started poll preparations in all 10 going to the polls. Will this create a conflict between the allies? State party chief Ajay Rai says no. "The SP is our ally and we'll fight the byelections together. We would like to contest in five seats, the ones where the BJP alliance won last time. There will be no shortages from the Congress side this election." ■

SHOW OF HANDS

- **LS poll wins gives new confidence to Congress, party upbeat on bypolls**
- **Seva Dal buzzing again; 'Samvidhan Samman' meetings held in bypoll seats**

UPFRONT

The RG Kar rape and murder case is still being examined in the Supreme Court, but a rather more innocuous matter has got the West Bengal government running after the wheels of justice. Sometime after the Durga Puja festival, it will file a petition with the SC, requesting a revision of a 2008 order by the Calcutta High Court that scrapped all commercial vehicles over 15 years old plying in the Kolkata Metropolitan Area (KMA). The move betrays a desperation to save the city's 'vanishing buses'. Once the preferred mode of commute for Kolkatans, the number of buses in the city has fallen drastically. The realisation hit hard when authorities figured that around 1,500 privately owned buses will go off the roads in 2024-25 courtesy the 2008 order. Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee asked the transport department to legally contest the vehicle scrapping policy in August.

Before 2009—when the policy was implemented—around 6,500 privately owned buses would ply in the KMA, which includes the municipal corpora-



DEBAJYOTI CHAKRABORTY

DYING NUMBERS Commuters board a WBTC bus in Kolkata